

water, he refuses to open his mind to the existence of ghosts. In *Don't Look Now*, seeing is not believing: you must believe in order to see.

Roeg and his writers, Allan Scott and Chris Bryant, find moments of sly humor in John's willful "blindness." When he loses his way in the labyrinthine alleyways of Venice, he pauses beneath an optician's sign (in the shape of a huge pair of glasses). "Do look now!" it seems to say, but he ignores it and hurries on. In another scene, John is

John follows the red coat on the Calle di Mezzo to the gates of the Palazzo Grimani where he encounters the dwarf.

mistaken for a peeping tom while searching for the home of the peculiar sisters. Other characters have no problems navigating the city, but John is forever getting lost and finding himself back where he started. For him, time and space are jumbled up and compressed, just as they are in Roeg's editing.

Venetian setting

Venice is the perfect backdrop for a horror movie about déjà vu; there are reminders of death and decay around every corner, and its bridges and canals all seem to look alike. Shot on location in and around the Italian vacation destination, *Don't Look Now* mostly avoids the tourist

traps; St. Mark's Square, for example, makes a single, easy-to-miss appearance. The movie sticks to the backwaters, creating a trap of its own from a maze of dank passages, churches, and empty hotels.

Much of Roeg's Venice is unseen: the audience hears cries in the night, a piano playing somewhere nearby, footsteps that echo all around. "Venice is like a city in aspic," says the blind clairvoyant. "My sister hates it. She says it's like after a dinner party, and all the guests are dead and gone. Too many shadows." The camera lingers on dust-sheeted furniture and shuttered windows, suggesting something concealed from view.

